PERFORMING MASCULINITY: EXAMINING MEN'S EXPERIENCES OF GENDER-BASED VIOLENCE

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Introduction

- Scholarship on gender-based violence (GBV) has predominantly emphasized violence committed by men against women (Javaid 2016a).
- Research on male sexual victimization is vastly understudied (Weiss 2010; Javaid 2016a, 2016b).
- Yet, both men and boys are victims of GBV (Ferrales & McElrath, 2014). One out of every 6 men will have experienced sexual abuse before age eighteen (Hlavka 2016).
- This work examines explanations accounting for why GBV occurs against men and boys.

Defining Gender-Based Violence

- Scholarship frequently employs the terms *rape, sexual violence,* and *gender-based violence* interchangeably (Ferrales et al., 2014).
- Most literature narrowly focuses on rape, however, GBV is much broader (Ferrales et al., 2014).
- GBV encompasses a range of physical and psychological components e.g., penetration, sexual assault, actions that sexually harass men and boys (Ferrales et al., 2014).

Defining Hegemonic Masculinity

- *Hegemonic masculinity* establishes normative ideals of how men should behave (Javaid 2016a).
- Literature reveals a link between hegemonic masculinity and crime (Ferrales, Brehm, McElrath, 2016).
- Explains why males fail to report and identify themselves as victims of crime (Weiss 2010, 2011; Javaid 2016a, 2016b).
- Desires to meet masculine expectations are a strong influencing factor for why perpetrators engage in crime (Copes & Hochstetler, 2003; Peralta, Tuttle, & Steele, 2010).

Perpetrator

- Perpetrators use violence to "Boost, preserve, [and] execute hegemonic masculinity to gain power and control" (Javaid 2016b; Peralta et al., 2010; Weiss, 2010).
- Their acts perpetuate hierarchies of masculinities (Hlavka 2016).
- Hegemonic masculinity privileges elite males at the expense of others (Javaid 2016b).
- Violence functions as an alternative solution for men facing "masculine deficiency" e.g., not being able to provide financially (Peralta et al., 2010; Weiss 2010; Javaid 2016b).
- They engage in other forms of crime as well (both sexual and non-sexual offenses) (Copes et al., 2003; Peralta et al., 2010).

Victim

Males who have experienced GBV have difficulty conceptualizing themselves as victims (Weiss 2011).

List of Male Rape Myths

Myth 1	• Men, by their nature, want sex and are always the sexual initiators (Weiss 2010).
Myth 2	• "Real men" cannot be victims (Javaid 2016b).
Myth 3	• "Real man" cannot be raped (Weiss 2010; Javaid 2016a).
Myth 4	• Men cannot be raped by other men (Javaid 2016b).
Myth 5	• Male victims who are assaulted or raped by other men will be labeled as "gay" (Weiss 2010; Hlavka 2016).
Myth 6	• Women cannot victimize men (Weiss 2010).
Myth 7	• If a man has an erection or ejaculates, he must have consented (Weiss 2010, 2011).

Frames of Victimization

Males perform hegemonic masculinity in order to reclaim, reassert, and repair their status, including in how they recount their victimization (Weiss 2010; Javaid 2016a).

The following are two methods of framing that male victims use while verbally recalling their experiences (Weiss 2010).

Intoxication

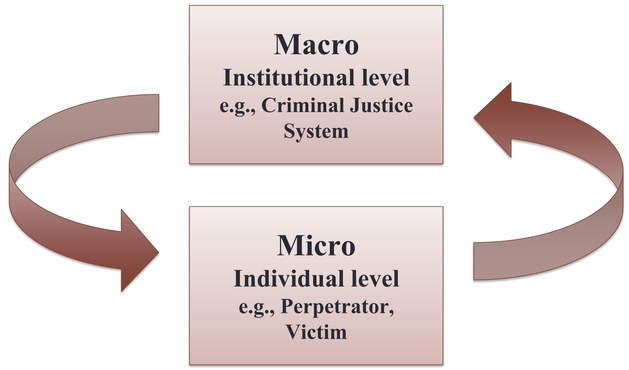
- Males attribute their sexual victimization to heavy drinking e.g., stating too drunk to control the situation (Weiss 2010).
- Males are three times more likely to mention being impaired because of intoxication (Weiss 2010).

Fighting Back

- Fighting back is a masculine trait (Weiss 2010).
- Failure to fight off an aggressor is linked with femininity (Weiss 2010).
- The male victim is asserting that he is not "gay" by physically retaliating against his male perpetrator (Weiss 2010, 2011; Javaid 2016a, 2016b).

Micro-Macro Theoretical Process

Hegemonic Masculinity cyclically influences the perpetuation of GBV at both the individual and institutional level.



- Social structure privileges hegemonic masculinity (Javaid 2016b) and is present and valued in all parts of social life (Javaid 2016a).
- It is continually constructed and what it means to be a "man" is reinforced, reproduced and recreated through social interaction (Peralta et al., 2010).
- Emphasis on hegemonic masculinity explains the perpetuation of GBV at the individual level (Copes et al., 2003). It reproduces the social structure and is perpetuated at all social levels (Peralta et al., 2010).

Policy Implications

- Providing more effective methods for violence prevention (Javaid 2016b).
- Promotion of gender equality (Javaid 2016b).
- Expand research beyond U.S. case including work in conflict settings (Ferrales et al., 2016).
- Further investigating the links between hegemonic masculinity and the engagement of crime more generally i.e., assaults and thefts (Weiss 2011).
- Construct better responses by mental health professionals and criminal justice actors (Weiss 2011; Javaid 2016b).
- Informs explanations for why GBV occurs against women and girls (Peralta et al., 2010).

Future Directions

- Expand research to the conflict setting in Darfur, Sudan.
- Code U.S. State Department's Atrocity Documentation Survey to detail frames male victims employ when recounting their victimization.
- Analyze the data and prepare article for publication.

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